

BANA5160 Capstone:

Unit 1 — Team Dynamics

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Unit 1: Team Dynamics

Welcome to the Course!

In this course, you will discover what it takes to build an effective team and apply the basic elements that make for successful project teamwork.

Faculty Authors



Laura Georgianna
Senior Lecturer
Samuel Curtis Johnson Graduate School of Management
Cornell SC Johnson College of Business

Laura Georgianna is a senior lecturer in Management and Organizations, executive director of Leadership Programs, and the director of the Roy H. Park Leadership Fellows program at the Johnson Graduate School of Management at Cornell. Through these roles, Ms. Georgiana oversees the articulation of the Johnson School's perspective on leadership and strategy for building the leadership capability of each business student. Ms. Georgianna has spent her career working with leaders and their organizations to empower them to deliver results, grow the business, and achieve long-term goals.

Before Cornell, Ms. Georgianna was senior director of organizational capability and development at Welch Allyn, Inc., where she led talent management, leadership development, performance management, and organizational development for the firm. Prior to that, she held roles in executive education, transformational change, and organizational development at Merck & Co. Inc. She also spent a number of years with Thomson Financial, now Thomson Reuters, in Account Services leadership roles. Ms. Georgianna earned an MBA with distinction from the Johnson School, where she was a Roy H. Park Leadership Fellow, and a Master of Industrial and Labor Relations from Cornell's Industrial and Labor Relations School. She also holds a B.A. from the University of Rochester, where she graduated Summa Cum Laude.





Jamie Hintlian
Visiting Lecturer
Samuel Curtis Johnson Graduate School of Management
Cornell SC Johnson College of Business

Jamie Hintlian is a Principal at Ernst & Young (EY) and leads the Life Sciences Supply Chain practice. Mr. Hintlian works with clients to improve their supply chain performance, including manufacturing strategy, plant operations, and supply chain planning. He has been a pioneer in leading industry initiatives concerning safe and secure supply chains and regulatory compliance. Prior to EY, Mr. Hintlian worked for over 20 years at Accenture, where he also lead the Global Health and Life Sciences Supply Chain. Additionally, he built and led the Pharmaceutical Business Unit of Aspen Technology. Mr. Hintlian has helped lead a supply chain and manufacturing strategy class at Cornell's Johnson School as an assistant instructor and often presents as a guest speaker. Mr. Hintlian has earned a B.S. and Master of Engineering in operations research from Cornell University, and an MBA from the Johnson Graduate School of Management at Cornell.



Unit 1: Team Dynamics

Video Transcript

Welcome to Team Dynamics. We've all had experience with teams that have succeeded and others that have really struggled; we want your teams to succeed. So we're going to spend some time together exploring what will make your team most effective. This discussion is going to happen in five different components. The first one is a look at trust, which is really at the heart or the core of every effective team. We're then going to explore what it takes to gain alignment: How do we make sure that we're all aligned towards a common set of goals and desired outcomes? We're going to look at what it takes to foster collaboration and make sure that we're really getting the benefits of working together collectively in a team. We're going to look at what it takes to really make good decisions and drive our team to action, and then ultimately, what can we do to make sure that our team environment is a place where we as individuals and collectively as a team can grow and perform?

So the purpose of our discussion here is really to equip you with knowledge and frameworks and tools that can assist you and the members of your broader team in establishing and growing as a team, one that can be as effective as possible and ultimately achieve your desired results. So let's go ahead and get started.

What you'll do

- **Build trust in team-based work**
- **Develop alignment to increase speed to performance**
- **Create collaborative outcomes**
- **Enable effective decision making and team accountability**
- **Establish a mindset of continuous improvement for the individual and the team**



Unit Description

Teamwork is essential to project success and a highly functioning team can lead to creative problem solving and better outcomes. Research shows that people are more likely to take calculated risks, leading to



innovation with the support of their team members. But what makes for an effective team?

In this unit, Ms. Georgianna shares her career insights collaborating with leaders and their organizations to explain the key components of building effective teams to enable desired results. You will go from building trust to learning to increase growth and performance, both individually and collectively. When applied to your capstone team, this concept will help your team increase the potential for innovation while working together towards a common goal to deliver results.

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Module Introduction: **Build Trust**



You are about to join a team and engage in a team project. Have you thought about what it takes to be effective as a cohesive team? You will have the opportunity to learn what is at the heart of any effective team: trust. Ms. Laura Georgianna shares the components of trust development and how quickly trust can erode. You will start a reflection journal in preparation for your capstone teamwork, responding to questions that will put you on a trajectory toward high performance.

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Watch: Why Trust Is Beneficial in Teams and Organizations

What does it mean to have trust in others? Ms. Georgianna explains what it means to have trust in a team and how it can yield higher productivity and cost savings for any team organization.

Video Transcript

Trust is really the heart or the foundation of any effective team — actually, really any individual relationship, team, organization. There's a lot of research that's been done on trust and what the role of trust in organizations is. Generally, the outcome of a lot of that research is that we know that the greater trust, it drives greater efficiency, and it reduce costs inside our organizations. So the more we can foster trust, the better the results we're going to get as an organization.

Now, one example of this that comes to mind is how organizations handled the transition to remote work for employees during the COVID-19 pandemic. We saw a really wide range of responses to the challenge of "How do we take our employees who've been working in the office and have them all of a sudden all working from home?" What was interesting is on one end of the continuum, one of the first things working some organizations did, where there was lower trust, was they went right to "How are we going to monitor our people and make sure that they're working?" They set up software systems that would track people's time on their computers. They set up phone lines that people would call into to say, "I'm starting work, or I'm going to lunch," and people were staffing those phone lines to track people's time. What's interesting there, if we think about this formula around trust, is there's cost associated with putting those systems in place, with staffing those phone lines, and having time tracked and analyzed. There's also efficiency risks associated with it, both because you have people spending time logging their time when they could be doing other work, but also because you're signaling to people that you don't trust them. What we know about motivation and human motivation is that when I'm being signaled that you don't trust me, I'm not going to work as hard. You are also having reduced efficiency because people were not feeling cared for in the same way or trusted in the same way as they could by the organization that they were working for.

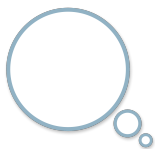
Let's go to the other end of the continuum. The organizations that had deep levels of trust in their employees, their first thought wasn't "How do I track your time when you're



home to make sure that you're working?" Their thought was, "How do I give you a structure that's going to allow you to deliver the results which I know you want to deliver for your team, for your work, for your department, for our organization?" They were looking at "How do I support you to make sure you have the right technology at home? How do I make sure that you are able to get your work done while also having the flexibility you might need because you have kids doing remote schooling, or you have elder parents that you may be trying to figure out how to take care of during the pandemic? I'm going to trust you to get your work done, and how can I help create structures that are going to allow you to do that?"

Interestingly enough, when you look at those results for most of those organizations, there were actually some reductions in cost — potentially with not having some of the infrastructure of the office that they were paying for — but that's secondary; I think that what really showed up was the increased efficiency component. Which is, people were working really hard to make sure that they could still deliver results in these organizations during the pandemic. So much so that many of those organizations, as people started to return to the office, said, "You know what? We can probably still give you some of this flexibility that you had because you were delivering your results and what I'm hearing is that this flexibility was really beneficial to you." Those organizations kept some roles remote, went to some hybrid roles, and the reality and the outcome of that was in many cases greater efficiency because of the motivations of the employees within the organization and they're feeling trusted, and they're feeling respected. I'd like you to think about your organization, either organizations you might be working with today, organizations you've been a part of in the past, teams that you're on. What might be things that have allowed and really fostered trust, or eroded trust in them? What is something that you could do as a part of some team or organization you're a part of today that could increase trust and as a result, increase efficiency or decrease cost for that team, that department or organization overall?

Source: Covey, Stephen M. R. *Speed of Trust*. Simon & Schuster, 2008.



Consider This

What can you do to increase trust in your team or organization?

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Watch: Components of Trust Development

How does it feel to be vulnerable? In this video, learn the building blocks of trust and how time and vulnerability impact the development of trust within a team.

Video Transcript

It's trust being important in the development of our individual relationships as well as our relationships within teams. It's important to spend a few minutes trying to understand how do we develop trust? What are the components of whether or not somebody trusts us or not? There's a lot of different models based on a lot of research in this space. What's interesting though, is when you look at the models, I would say they all pretty much boil down to the same elements, just using different words.

One of the models that I like, partially because of its simplicity, has essentially three pieces to it. The first piece is logic: When I am trying to decide whether or not I can trust you, I'm going to look at your logic. Do I feel as though you will use good judgment, make sound decisions, if you're off doing work on behalf of the team, that you're going to think critically and really thoughtfully about the contributions that you're making on behalf of the larger team.

If I feel as though the logic is there and it's really solid, another thing I'm going to be looking for is your authenticity. Do I feel as though who you're showing me is truly, authentically you? Or is it that you potentially have a facade or you're trying to present yourself in a way that you think I want to see you versus who you truly are? If I'm feeling that there's that wall, that facade, I'm going to be much less likely to trust you than if I feel as though you're just being your authentic self. Part of being our authentic selves is being willing to be a little bit transparent and vulnerable relative to things we're thinking about, things we're feeling. Those types of sharing are the things that are going to cause somebody to connect with us and see us as being authentic.

The third component of this model of trust is whether or not I believe that you're empathetic to me and to other members of our team, our department, whoever it is that we're interfacing with. Are you just out for yourself and your own goals and your own aspirations, or do you truly care about what's important to me, my situation, my goals, or the goals for us collectively as a team? If I truly believe that you are in it for more than yourself and that you are willing to work collectively and collaboratively based upon the

other broader goals beyond your own, I'm also going to be significantly more likely to trust you.

So what's interesting is that in order to build trust, it doesn't just happen in a snap. It is through a wide variety of really small incremental interactions, that over time I'm cataloguing these different elements of this model to decide whether or not I can trust you. It takes quite a while for trust — really deep trust, anyway — to build. The challenge, though, is we can lose trust really quickly. One misstep, one place where we don't necessarily demonstrate these things and it can erode trust and then it can be an even slower process to rebuild that trust over time. Now in the space of authenticity, I mentioned this idea of vulnerability. Vulnerability is critical to our ability to build trust. If we are not showing some of our potential points where we feel exposed, the likelihood is that we're not necessarily going to have that trust built. One of the terms I tend to like to use in this space is incremental, reciprocal vulnerability, and the idea here is I'm going to be a little bit vulnerable with you and I'm going to wait and see your response. You're going to be a little bit vulnerable with me, and then you're going to wait to see my response. And over time, we're going to do this incrementally with each other until we grow to a deeper level of collective and shared trust.

Now, one thing to note in this idea of incremental, reciprocal vulnerability is sometimes what feels vulnerable to me may not feel vulnerable to you, and something that might feel vulnerable to you is not what feels vulnerable to me, and so we need to watch for cues from others that are telling us that they are being vulnerable in a moment, and then be really proactive and thoughtful in the way that we respond, such that they feel as though this is a safe space for further growth and further trust. And if we're able to do that with each other, ultimately we're going to get to these deeper levels of trust that are going to help us as individuals and our partnerships as well as teams to be significantly more effective and have greater results, because of that trust that we have established together.

Source: Frei, Frances X., and Anne Morriss. "Begin with trust." *Harvard Business Review* 98.3 (2020).

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Read: Building Trust in Relationships — Peaches and Coconuts

For us to connect authentically with another person we tend to go through a series of interactions in which we each take turns being slightly vulnerable and then observing the reaction and reciprocation from the other person. If the reaction and reciprocation are favorable, then we share a bit more, and a bit more, until over time we have shared enough that the other party can confidently say that they feel that they know us and can trust that we are sharing our authentic selves.

This process can feel lopsided if the parties involved have different perceptions of what type of sharing makes one vulnerable, as our reciprocity often somewhat mirrors what is shared by others. See the article about peaches and coconuts from Erin Myer's book, "The Culture Map": **"One Reason Cross-Cultural Small Talk Is So Tricky"**.

As a result, be aware of the subtleties that are layered within the other party's communication as you assess their progress in attempting to build trust. Conversely, make sure you are stretching yourself to a place of vulnerability, no matter where that line is for others, as this is what allows you to see the other's response to your vulnerability and proceed along the path toward trust.

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☆ Key Points

We have to share things that make us feel vulnerable if any depth of relationship is to be created and trust established.

What feels vulnerable will vary from one person to the next.

We need to be aware of this in our interactions with others, especially when they are cross-cultural interactions.

Watch: Eroding Trust

Trust can be slow to build and easy to lose. Ms. Georgianna recommends a simple technique to help spot and prevent behaviors that erode trust within a team.

Video Transcript

Trust, being slow to develop, is able to be very quickly eroded. The interesting thing is that there's research that tells us that what we do that causes others to not trust us tends to be similar from situation to situation, such that there are patterns as to how we trip up in the process of building trust with others. As a result, it can be really helpful to be reflective on times when maybe somebody else stopped trusting you or wasn't able to establish trust with you, or even think about times when maybe you lost trust in someone else. There tend to be insights in those experiences that can help you to see patterns that if you know them, you can be proactive about trying to mitigate. If we think about our three component model relative to trust, for some of us, logic is our point of wobble. Maybe we are a big ideas person and we love to be thinking about new ideas, but we don't really necessarily love the execution side of things. So it's not uncommon that somebody might be expecting us to deliver something that we don't deliver on time. That can be a wobble, as I like to call it, in people's ability to be able to trust us. Similarly, authenticity might be our wobble. We may be so concerned about somebody experiencing us in a certain way or us trying to show up in a way that we think people want us to, that we have so much of a protective guard up that people don't see who we truly are, and that ends up being the place that erodes other people's ability to trust us. Or maybe you have an empathy wobble. Maybe you get so excited to drive forward to the results that you're looking for, that you're not always paying attention to what's going on for other people, and in the process you may step on their toes or seem to be insensitive, and that can erode trust as well. If you can find your pattern, then you can be proactive in thinking about are there tools, are there processes, are there checks that you can put in place for yourself to catch yourself before you necessarily wobble; techniques that can help you to mitigate those outcomes?

One simple technique you can do is to essentially be a little bit vulnerable with others relative to where your wobbles are. If you're able to proactively let somebody know, "Hey, you know, I get really excited when we get into projects and sometimes I can step on toes in my pursuit of the end goal, and I'm aware of this. If you ever feel as though I'm doing



this, please call it out and let me know." Simply doing that is a moment of vulnerability that in and of itself can increase trust because you're also giving people a frame by which they can interpret your behavior and they won't necessarily interpret it as likely in a way that erodes trust.

An example for me of this is that, especially early, in my career, I would say my pattern was an authenticity wobble. I was very concerned about making sure that I was showing up in the way that I was meant to show up, whether it was in front of peers at work, whether it was in front of clients that I was responsible for managing their accounts. And I noticed that over time, the energy that I was putting into trying to show up in a certain way was actually really causing a barrier to the development of the relationships. There were a couple of moments where even as I was trying to put up that facade, the facade broke down and maybe some of my insecurities or my vulnerabilities snuck out. Then what I started to notice was that when that happened, in some cases it actually deepened the relationship, but it made those relationships stronger. It wasn't easy. But I started to really work on trying to reduce my inner voice that caused that wall to be there and to just show up as myself and trust that that was going to be the right presence to bring to the relationship. Over time, I found that I was able to develop trust significantly more quickly and minimize the number of places where trust was eroded. I think it can be really helpful, and I challenge you to think about this: What are your trust wobbles and what are the things that you might be able to proactively do to minimize those? You're never going to get rid of them completely, but to minimize those and to be a little bit vulnerable with those around you such that you can have a better chance of deeper trust and less potential trust erosion.

Source: Freij, Frances X., and Anne Morriss. "Begin with trust." *Harvard Business Review* 98.3 (2020).

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Activity: Trust Self Assessment

Take a few minutes to think about trust in your current relationships and what you could do to increase trust in preparation for working in your capstone team. Just taking five to ten minutes to jot down your answers will go a long way.

Though this ungraded activity does not require formal submission, this will help you prepare for working with your capstone team.

Instructions:

Record your answer to the questions found in each of the following three topics. You can choose to save and export your answers at the end.

The full contents of this page cannot be rendered in the course transcript. Log in to the course to view it.

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Watch: Creating a Trust-based Team Environment

When we think of trust, having the comfort to bring up new ideas and challenge others is central to a functioning team. Ms. Georgianna breaks down the process of creating a safe team environment through the lens of psychological safety.

Video Transcript

When we think about trust at a team level, we think about it through a concept of psychological safety. What is psychological safety? Psychological safety within a team is the concept or the idea that as a team, as we're interacting with each other, we feel really comfortable bringing up new ideas and challenging each other's ideas. We feel as though it's a safe space to raise concerns, make suggestions, and when needed, ask each other for help and acknowledge where we might have gaps, and that all of these interactions are really just part of our working norms. They're the types of ways that we engage each other in order to get to our results and to drive our ideas forward. When we think about how do we build this; how do we build this psychologically safe space? If we think about it from an individual level, I can think about it from four stages.

The first stage is this idea of inclusion safety. As I start working with you, I'm going to show some of my authentic self and I'm going to see how the team responds. Do I need to put energy into showing up in certain ways, or can I just show up as me and fully engage in the work and that will be acceptable, that will be embraced? If I feel that, then I'm going to move on to what we would call learner safety. This is where I'm going to start to test what happens if I let the group know that there's something I don't know or understand. What happens when I ask the group a question or I ask the group for help? Maybe I make a mistake, how does the group respond in those moments? If I feel supported, I feel as though it's safe for those interactions; I'm going to be more likely to start sharing my ideas. This is where we move into contributor safety, where I'm going to start sharing a lot of ideas, I'm going to be active in my contributions to the team and what we're trying to achieve. Now, what's interesting, is as a contributor, I don't have to have the group accept all of my ideas and act on all of my ideas, but I want my ideas to feel heard. If I feel as though my ideas are heard, then I'm going to be significantly more likely to share more ideas and more contributions in the future.

Assuming that's going well, I may move to then the fourth stage of psychological safety, which is challenger safety. I'm going to start productively sharing where I may disagree,



where I may have a different opinion than somebody else in the group. Where I may have a concern that I think I need to raise relative to what it is that we're doing in relation to the results we're trying to get. I'm going to see how the group responds when I raise a concern or an issue, when I hopefully productively challenge ideas or the path that we're heading down.

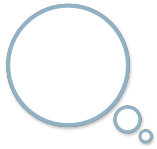
In order to create this space where all of this is happening, there are some things we can do up front. It helps if we have a sense of understanding of purpose, in both our collective purpose as a team, but also our individual purposes. What are we each hoping to get out of being on this team? If we can hold all of that purpose as a central point for what it is that we're doing, why it is that we're working together; that can naturally foster some of this safe space. We also really need to see and appreciate that there's an interdependence between us in order to achieve those goals. If we believe that we can achieve the goal on our own, the likelihood is we're not going to be demonstrating psychologically safe behaviors in the team. But if we can really see the power of our interdependence, we're going to be much more likely to act in the ways that foster psychological safety.

The other thing is this idea around failure — I talked about this a little bit in the learner safety space. We want to set some collective agreements about what are we going to do if we fail as a team or if an individual fails on a piece of the work that is in service of the team; how do we want to handle those things? The more that we can be proactive about creating a space where we can support each other so that maybe we minimize failures, but if we do have a failure, that we will handle it productively. That's also going to allow people to feel comfortable taking risks that may be important for the team. Then we also want to make sure that we validate all voices: Are we creating spaces for everybody's voice to feel valued and to be important in the work that we're doing? As we start working together on a day-to-day basis, we want to also make sure that we're being really humble, that there's a sense of humility, that there's not maybe certain members of the team that are more important or are better than others. But that we really appreciate and recognize each other's importance within the team. We want to create some really good norms for effective discussion and dialogue where we can be curious about each other's ideas and explore what's under them in with some really good critical thinking in a way that allows us to get to broader, better ideas out of our work together. When things get bumpy — which they will in every team — how do we make sure that we keep it a safe space in those tough moments? Making sure that we're listening to each other really well, that we're valuing and validating each other's perspectives, even if we don't disagree, and that when we have these bumps, that we take a very future-oriented approach to solving the challenges that we're facing versus looking backwards and pointing blame.



If we're able to do all of these things as a team, we're able to really create this type of space where every team member feels heard and valued. When we feel heard and valued, we contribute more and there's more learning and innovation that's able to occur; that's what really delivers results.

Source: Edmondson, Amy C. *The fearless organization: Creating psychological safety in the workplace for learning, innovation, and growth*. John Wiley & Sons, 2018.



Consider This

What are some ways you can create psychological safety within a team?

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Read: Building the Perfect Team

The New York Times Magazine article, “What Google Learned From Its Quest to Build The Perfect Team” by Charles Duhigg — also republished under the title “Group Study” — explores the concept of psychological safety as a critical factor in team success. It walks through the work of researchers within Google running an initiative called Project Aristotle. These researchers explored a breadth of data about teams within the firm, trying to identify what made a team high performing. After exploring the data from many perspectives, the main finding was that **psychological safety** was the primary determinant of team performance.

The full article is available to you as a Cornell University student. Access the article by following the directions below.

Directions:

1. **[Access the article “Group Study”](#)** through the Cornell Library.
2. Log in using your cornell.edu NetID.
3. Read the article on ProQuest.

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☆ Key Points

More than three-quarters of our day is spent communicating with colleagues.

Having the right norms in your team raises the group’s collective intelligence.

Psychological safety, a shared belief held by members of a team that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking, was the primary determinant of high-performing teams at Google.



Tool: Building Trust in Your Team

Trust and psychological safety are the foundation of our relationships individually and in teams. Use this tool as a reference to help you build trust with others and create a space in your teams where psychological safety can occur.

Download this document for future reference.

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 **Download the Tool**

Use this helpful tool **Building Trust in Your Team** to build trust with others.

Journal — Building Trust and Fostering Psychological Safety

You will have an opportunity to reflect on each of the foundational competencies of high performing teams in relation to the development of your capstone team. **The same reflection journal document will be used in all**

five modules of this unit. We ask that you download this document now and save it for easy reference. At the end of each module, we will ask you to open this reflection journal and respond to the prompts associated with the material just completed.

A completed individual reflection journal can then be taken to the launch of your capstone team. It is our hope that having done this reflection and having captured it all in one place, you will be able to proactively initiate dialogue within your team about how you want to work together and revisit these topics as needed, which will put you on the trajectory towards high performance.

Directions:

- Take a few minutes to respond to the Building Trust questions on page one
- Write in short, readable bullet points
- Quickly reference them later

Important instructions for saving your work:

When you open the linked PDF, it may open in a new browser window. Save it to your desktop or preferred storage location, then open it with Adobe Reader, and save a copy with a new name. This will give you a working copy that you can review, print, or add content to without losing your work. It will also enable you to retain a clean copy of the original document for future use.

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 [Download the Tool](#)

Use this helpful [Reflection Journal](#) to begin personally building trust with your team.

Module Wrap-up: **Build Trust**

You have now taken a closer look at trust, a foundation for building effective teams. Laura Georgianna discussed how deeper levels of trust are established and ways to reduce trust erosion. You examined how to create a trust-based team environment through psychological safety. You began your reflection journal, responding to how you can personally build trust and psychological safety within your capstone team.

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Module Introduction: Gain Alignment



Teamwork can be very rewarding. But there is nothing more frustrating than being a part of a project team when, despite meeting after meeting, nothing is actually produced. Ms. Laura Georgianna explains why this happens and what you can do about it. You will discover what it means to gain alignment and create shared norms that work for everybody in your team. You will begin to recognize the benefits of creating cultural awareness in cross-cultural teams. Your reflection journal will continue to be developed as you identify norms you want to proactively align your team with.

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Watch: Creating Shared Mental Models That Create Performance Outcomes

Ms. Georgianna introduces Tuckman's Stages of Group Development as a helpful guide to building a new team based on collective norms.

Video Transcript

As we start and establish a new team, there's a process that happens to get us up and running, and that ultimately creates the way that we will end up working together. One articulation of this process is Tuckman's stages of team development. This is a classic model; many of you may have seen this or versions of this before. But the idea is that as we form as a team, the first thing that happens is that we start to storm. We start to interact with each other, and the way that those interactions occur ends up building and creating what become our norms. In the storming phase, the first time someone shows up late to a meeting and how we respond to that starts to influence what our norm is going to be around time. The first time someone shows up to a meeting unprepared, the way we respond to that starts to build what our norms are going to be regarding meeting preparation. The first time two members of our team disagree, how we handle that conflict is going to start to inform the norms that we have regarding conflict and conflict resolution. As we interact over time, there is this organic process of norm development that starts to occur. What's interesting about this is as these norms develop, those norms directly inform our performance, the results that we get, how we actually end up delivering what it is we're trying to deliver as a team.

Now, the thing we want to think about that often times we don't do proactively in teams is a recognition that we can actually deliberately influence the norms that are being created versus just letting them happen organically. In doing so and being proactive in our norm development, we can aspire to set norms that are directly tied to the type of performance and outcomes that we're looking for. We may want to deliver a certain outcome in a certain amount of time, and if time sensitivity is really important, then we might develop different norms about how our meetings are going to be structured, or how our interactions are going to occur, what our expectations are of timeliness to respond to each other's emails. Those proactive alignment of expectations and norm creation can help us to move towards performance and execution of our goals much more quickly. The reality though, is as much as we may do some of that proactive upfront



work, when we start to roll up our sleeves and really start working together, some of those norms will carry through; some of them may start to slip. There's opportunities as a team to constantly be pausing, reflecting on how we're doing and making adjustments to our norms if we see that there are norms emerging that are not in service of the type of performance that we want to have. Team development isn't a linear process. It really is an iterative one. But there is work we can do upfront to help to shape the norms, to make sure that the norms that are developing in our team are the ones that are actually really going to help to drive us to the performance and the results that we're looking for.

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Watch: Gaining Alignment Across Cultural Differences

What is the best way to be a productive, multicultural team? Ms. Georgianna describes the difference between high- and low-context cultures, and how it can impact team dynamics and communication styles.

Video Transcript

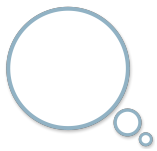
For many of us, the teams that we're becoming a part of are becoming more global, more cross-cultural. The idea of figuring out how to gain alignment and create shared norms can become even more complicated because different cultures will often have different norms around interaction that can show up in these cross-cultural teams. One such difference, which I've seen pretty consistently sort of show up in different team contexts, is the idea of whether or not an individual on the team is coming from a low context or a more high context culture. For those of us that come from more low context cultures, we tell it like it is. Meaning what the words are that come out of our mouth tend to be quite literal and say what it is that we're trying to communicate. The other end of the continuum are those of us that come from more high context cultures. When we talk about communication in high context cultures, we often will talk about the idea of reading the air; that while there are certain words that come out of our mouth, there's often a lot of implied meaning that's not actually said, but that other people who are coming from that same high context culture understand is there, even though I haven't directly communicated it.

In the high context culture, someone might say, "That's interesting." They may actually mean, "I'm going to be polite and basically we're going to put your idea aside and we're going to move forward and this is my way of letting you know gently that we're not going to proceed." What's interesting, though, is you could have a totally different high context culture where if I said, "That's interesting," what I mean is, "Tell me more. I think that's a fabulous idea and I really want us to move forward with it." If I come from a low context culture and I say, "That's interesting," I probably mean, "That's interesting, and maybe I want to talk about it a little bit more; I want to explore it further. I want to understand more about what it is that you're saying, because I think it's interesting." What's interesting to me, actually, about this example is that when we bring people from different cultures together, even if we have multiple people from high context cultures, if they're not from the same high context culture, we can't assume that anyone is going to



have an understanding of implied meaning; that's not in our actual language. What that requires us to do is to default to using more low context communication, because that's where we can develop shared meaning. Now, for those of us that come from more high context cultures, this can be challenging. It does often require a different level of or style of communication that can feel a bit uncomfortable.

One of the ways that we can help with this and mitigate this a little bit is actually the building of norms, and so the more proactive we can be in our norm development that allows members from different cultures to come together and say, "Here's how I tend to do things. Here's how I tend to respond to communications, here's how I tend to engage in conflict." We cannot only say, "Okay, well, what does that that mean for how we want to blend all of these differences into a shared norm?" But it also gives us greater awareness of each other's differences, so that if one member of the team is responding in a certain way, I may be able to interpret that response with a more cultural awareness than otherwise. As a result, I may be able to respond in a more productive way to that difference when it emerges. I would really suggest that the more you have cross-cultural teams, the more you are really aware of and deliberate about exploring the different working norms that may show up in your team and collaborating together on thinking about how to set norms that are going to work for everybody and ultimately create shared understanding and alignment that will drive results.



Consider This

Have you ever worked in a high- or low-context cross-cultural team? How did you create a shared understanding and alignment?

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Watch: Aligning Goals

Where do you start to build alignment within your teams? Explore ways to first establish shared goals and how different goals influence conflict engagement and performance.

Video Transcript

As we look to build alignment within our teams, the place we need to start is an alignment of goals. We want to think about alignment both around what are the collective goals that we're trying to achieve as a team, but we also want to be aware of what are the individual goals that each member of the team have that they're hoping to be able to achieve through the work on the team. The more that we have awareness of all of those goals, the more we're going to be able to inform the choices that we make relative to the norms that we set. If we think about this idea of norms driving performance, we want to make sure that those norms are in service of our goals versus potentially developing norms that might be in conflict with the goals that we're trying to achieve, because different norms will create different results. Let me just give you an example.

Let's say that we have a goal as a team to really create deep relationships and connection with each other. A moment of conflict arises. How we handle that conflict and the norms that we might establish about the way we want to engage in conflict might look very different if we have a goal about relationship development. Then if, say, we have a goal about efficient execution of our work, if our goal is efficient execution, our way of engaging in conflict may be significantly more direct and digging quickly into the facts. Whereas if we have the relationship goal, our way of handling conflict may be much more about deep listening, seeking to understand, validating each other's perspectives, and whatnot. The work of exploring goals first before setting norms is what's going to allow you to make sure that you're setting the norms that are going to be in service of the results you're looking for.

Now, it's not uncommon that when you start to explore goals, you find that there's actually goals that team members have that might feel at odds with each other. I might be looking to develop relationships, you may be looking for the team to execute its work as efficiently as possible. Now, on the surface would be "That's really challenging. What are we going to do? We can't service both of those goals." What I'd ask you to do is pause and get creative because there are oftentimes ways that you can recognize and adjust

norms to try to meet some level of each of the different individual goals that may exist on the team. While recognizing that you need to make sure your norms are in service of the collective goals of the group. It's harder work sometimes to do that if the goals are at odds with each other. But what I would argue is it's better to know that up front, as you are trying to establish the team and to think about norms, then to have those different goals emerge partway through when things get heated and your sleeves are rolled up and you're deep in the work of the team and you're having conflict with each other because you're not working in service of each other's goals. Get this idea early in your team formation, and I think that what you'll find is you're able to be much more proactive in developing norms that help you to succeed as individuals and as a collective team.

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Watch: Organizing

Team members can have diverse preferences when it comes to how to organize the work of a team. Ms. Georgianna divides these preferences into four major categories.

Video Transcript

So as we work to proactively establish norms for how we want to work together as a team, one of the things we want to think about is how do we want to organize our interactions? I've broken down organizing our interactions into four categories that I want to touch on. The first is the idea of time: What does being on time look like? This really varies quite greatly from person to person, and oftentimes actually there are some cultural threads about how we think about time that can show up in how different people perceive being on time. For some of us, being on time means I'm there five minutes early, I've got all of my documents, my material ready to go so when the clock starts for that meeting, we are off and running. For others, they show up within 10 to 15 minutes of when the stated time is. That's plenty acceptable being on time and we can proceed whenever everybody is all there.

Another element of time that's important to pay attention to relative to our norms is the time of day that works best for people. Some of us work much better collaboratively first thing in the morning, in the afternoon, some of us, late night understanding what some of our preferences are for working together with others is an important additional element of time. There's also sometimes individual constraints that because us to have commitments outside of the team that don't allow us to work together in certain times. Those constraints might also impact our ability to be on time, and so the more we can be proactive to explain what are some of our boundaries or our constraints and what might be a risk that would because us to not be on time and share this with our team, the more than the team can figure out either: a, Let's make some changes to how we're going to work together to minimize the impact to you of these of these challenges or constraints; and or if you are, in fact, late, by whatever our definition is, we at least now have context to understand why that might be. We're not going to assume you don't care about the team or you're disrespectful to us, but we're going to assume that probably the things you shared with us that might be your constraints are, in fact, causing you a delay and that you'll hopefully be with us shortly.

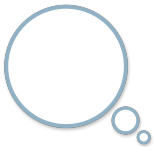
The second area within organizing our interactions is the idea of planning. Some of us love to have a plan, right? We're going to have an agenda for every meeting, we're going to have a project plan with all sorts of workstreams and milestones, and that's what really helps us to feel like we are prepared to do the work and do it as efficiently and effectively as possible. For others, putting all that time into planning feels like a waste of time, and I'd rather just all get in the room, start the work, and you know what — we're going to just work through it, and it'll all get done, and I'm going to trust that it'll get done even if we don't have all of those structures in place.

The third area around organizing our interactions is flow. Some of us feel really comfortable in that just-in-time space and others really like to have things done significantly in advance. If we have a presentation at noon, are you somebody who wants to have everything set and ready to go for that presentation the day before or are you okay with working on that presentation until 11:30, as long as there's enough time to get to the room where the presentation is occurring? For different people, flow and where the flow ends up falling can create stress or energy. And so we want to be aware of what stresses somebody out versus what energizes somebody when it comes to flow. The more we're aware of those things, the more we can respond to our teammates and their reactions in moments where they may be feeling stressed or they may not be feeling energized because of the point of the journey that we're in, relative to the work that we're doing.

The fourth area around organizing our interactions is roles and responsibilities. Some of us like to have very clearly outlined roles and responsibilities for every element of the work that we're doing. Others, let's just all jump in, roll up our sleeves, start doing the work, and we'll let the roles form organically. Either of these can be fine, but I will say that I have a slight bias towards making sure, some way or another, that all of the key roles and the responsibilities of the work that needs to get done are in fact covered whether you proactively cover them before you start the work or you take moments to pause while you're in the work to double check that, organically, all of those roles have been taken on somehow by different members of the team. Now for many of us, our preferences in these areas and other areas of norms are pretty strong. I will say there's no right or wrong answer to these; even if it might feel to you like there is, and in fact that your preference is the right answer. What's valuable here and what's useful to you as a team is to surface these preferences early in the process. That allows you to then be proactive to say, "Based on what we know of our preferences, based on what we know of our goals as a team, what are the types of norms that we want to establish that are either going to trend with our preferences or that we may need to establish, because of or in spite of

our preferences, because we know that some of our preferences may not actually be in service of our goals?" If we can be proactive in using this knowledge and information in our norm development, we're going to drive ourselves much more aggressively towards the positive performance we're looking for.





Consider This

How do you like to organize your interactions within teams?

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Activity: Your Organizing Preferences

As you think about organizing your work when working in teams, answer the following questions to describe your individual organizing preferences. At the end of this activity, you will be able to print your answers to reference during team norm development discussions.

Though this ungraded activity does not require formal submission, this will help you prepare for working with your capstone team.

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Watch: Interacting

Ms. Georgianna dives deeper into the different types of interactions that can occur within a team, both between team members and in their work environments.

Video Transcript

As we work on alignment as a team, one of the things we want to think about is how do we want to interact with each other? One of the categories under interaction that we want to explore is the idea of commitment. To be really honest with ourselves, what level of commitment are we planning to give to this team, given other things that may be on our plate, other commitments outside of this team that we have, and what is the level of commitment we're expecting from the other members of the team? Does everyone need to give the same level of commitment for the team to succeed? Some people feel really strongly that we all have to all be 100 percent in to make this team work. In other situations, people may be comfortable with saying, you know what? I can give about 80 percent to this team and I'm okay as long as everyone's giving 50 to 80 percent. That may be consistently for the team, or it may be that we recognize that at different points in the team's life cycle, we may be looking for different people to give different amounts.

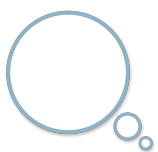
The other thing we want to explore when we're thinking about commitment is what does it look like for somebody to be committed? What signals someone's commitment when I'm observing them in our team interactions? For some of us, it might be that people show up prepared or they show up on time; those are things that tell me you're committed. For others, it might be you're willing to stay late if we don't have something completed and and put in that little bit of extra effort to make sure that we get something done. As we're thinking about commitment, one of the things that can be helpful is to proactively share with each other what are our other obligations that may be getting in the way or have the potential to get in the way of us being able to be as committed as we want to to the team. We do have, most all of us, some level of competing priorities and there may be times where we have to make trade-offs. If we can be proactive with folks about sharing what those are, it can help to create more productive conversation, if members of the team are feeling as though another member may not be as committed as they need them to be in order for the team to succeed.

The second area around our interactions has to do with conflict: How do each of us tend to respond to conflict? Are we somebody who tends to avoid conflict and hope it goes

away, do we tend to defer in default to other people, do we tend to fight to win or are we willing to make some level of give and take compromises to try to find outcomes that meet multiple perspectives or needs? Now, how we want to handle conflict in this team should be tied to what our stated goals are. What are the things that we're trying to achieve and then what is the type of conflict norms that we might want to establish that will help us to deliver on the results that we're looking for, even if those norms may not fully align with what some of our default preferences tend to be as individuals.

The third category of interacting norms we want to explore is the type of work environment we want to work in. Say we're working together in person: Do we like private, quiet spaces where there's no distractions, or do we love to actually meet and gather in busy locations that have some energy and hum to them, and that really helps us to feel energized and connected. If we're meeting virtually, we want to ask some similar questions: Do we want people to all be in a quiet space that doesn't have distractions? Are we going to ask folks to remove other devices or technology or things that may get in the way of being able to stay fully focused? Do we want to use certain sorts of tools in our environment that can help us to create shared outcomes and content? If we're in person, that might be whiteboards or flip charts; if we're virtual, that might be Google Docs or other shared screen types of technologies and whatnot. The last category that we want to explore here in how we want to interact is our communication preferences. Getting alignment on when do we want to use text, when do we want to use e-mail, when is it the time to just pick up the phone, have a live phone call with each other or a live meeting with each other. I've seen teams over time really struggle sometimes with this when you have certain people who use text for everything or people who never check their e-mail.

The more we can be proactive in identifying "Here what our norms need to be relative to different communication preferences, and here's what our agreements are about how to use them, how we will respond when we want to escalate to a different communications preference." It can be very helpful to have that to fall back on once you start working together as a team. Because sometimes when you try to just let this happen organically, you'll find that you don't end up choosing the most productive communication tools for the task at hand.



Consider This

How do you typically handle conflict? How do you prefer to communicate?

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Activity: Your Interacting Preferences

As you think about working in teams, answer the following questions to describe your individual interacting preferences. At the end of this activity, you will be able to print your answers to reference during team norm development discussions.

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Watch: Executing

Have you ever been part of a team that meets frequently but never actually makes progress? Aligning unique work styles will help teams maximize their effectiveness. Ms. Georgianna describes how teams can work together to reconcile their differences in executing tasks.

Video Transcript

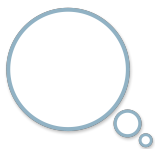
One common challenge that teams have is that they meet, but they leave the meeting feeling like they didn't really make forward progress towards their goals. There's nothing more frustrating than being a part of a team that feels like it's just like spinning its wheels. What are some of the things that we can explore from a norms perspective to help us make sure that as a team, we're executing really well?

One of the first things we can look at is preparation: What does it mean to be prepared for a meeting? Both what do we expect from others on the team; how they show up, how prepared they are when they arrive at a meeting, but also, what can we realistically commit to for the level of preparation that we're going to do in advance to show up for our meetings and our interactions with our team? The second category is solution development. Some of us love to co-create in the moment with each other, developing everything collectively as we go. Others really appreciate getting to do solo work, to think about solutions separately, come together, share ideas, and then go off and do work independently again, checking back in over time to make sure that we have alignment; but a fair amount of the work actually being done independently. Another element around solution development that's important to explore is the idea of the use of data. Some of us tend to be more instinct oriented, where we review a situation, something that we're trying to work on as a team, and we sort of go, "You know what, our gut tells us that this is probably how we should proceed." Then we go and we look for data that supports that instinct. Others are very heavy on what I would call the investigation side of our use of data, where they start from the bottom up, really looking at the data, analyzing it, and trying to call out of that data, what truly is the right solution for going forward.

A third area that we want to explore relative to how we want to execute together is tone: What is our preferred tone for our meetings? Is it all business? We're here to get this done, we're going to be super efficient, we're not going to chit chat; it is all about the project. Some of us, it's about the project, but let's have a little bit of fun in there; a little

how was your weekend or some humor here and there. Then there's others who, you know what, "I just love being together with you guys, and let's have a whole lot of fun, and let's sprinkle some of the work in along the way." Challenge can be, if we have differing preferences there, it can feel really frustrating if you're not seeing either some of the seriousness or some of the fun in the tone that's showing up in your meetings.

The fourth is the idea of focus. Some of us are all about one task: Let's put those blinders on, and we're going to just focus on getting this one task done. For others, it's really about multitasking and trying to do maybe multiple things at once. As a team, we could be moving in parallel directions, on different pieces of the project at the same time. Similarly, from a focus perspective, some of us like to work in really small chunks and take lots of breaks, whereas others it's like, "You know what, lock that door until we get it done and we're going to power through." Recognizing those differences is important because those differences can really influence somebody's energy level relative to their contributions. So knowing where the preferences are can help you to design your meetings, in a way that can get the maximum energy and effort out of all of the members of the team. One of the things you'll want to think about is what signals, for you, that someone is focused? Because if you tend to be a single-task person and others are jumping around between different tasks, you may interpret that that means they're not focused. But for them, that might actually be their peak focus approach, because it's stimulating multiple ideas and thoughts within them. So having a conversation early on about what focus looks like, can help you to interpret what other people's behaviors are, to make sure that you're accurately assessing their level of dedication or focus to the execution of the work on the team.



Consider This

Think about how past teams you have been on were executed. How did it go?

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Activity: Your Executing Preferences

As you think about working in teams, answer the following questions to describe your individual executing preferences. At the end of this activity, you will be able to print your answers to reference during team norm development discussions.

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Journal — Gaining Alignment

Using the same Reflection Journal document you downloaded in the first module, open and complete the second set of questions.

Directions:

- Complete the Gaining Alignment boxes on page two
- Write in short, readable bullet points
- Quickly reference them later on

Important instructions for saving your work:

When you open the linked PDF, it may open in a new browser window. Save it to your desktop or preferred storage location, then open it with Adobe Reader, and save a copy with a new name. This will give you a working copy that you can review, print, or add content to without losing your work. It will also enable you to retain a clean copy of the original document for future use.

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 **Download the Tool**

Use the same **Reflection Journal** to identify norms that you would like to discuss with your team.

Module Wrap-up: Gain Alignment

The material presented in this module focused on how to gain alignment to increase speed to performance. Laura Georgianna differentiated between low- and high-context cultures and different styles of communication. You explored creative ways to shape your work to achieve individual and collective goals that work in service for your entire team while considering various styles of conflict, work environment, and communication preferences. By exploring your own preferences around organizing, interacting, and executing and then reflecting on these norms in your journal, you are able to work more harmoniously with teammates and organize your interaction with them to drive positive results.

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Module Introduction: **Foster Collaboration**



Why work in teams and what advantages could it bring? Ms. Laura Georgianna explains the advantages of working in diverse teams. This module introduces a model for understanding how we come to conclusions and how this awareness can be used to achieve better collaboration. Your reflection journal will continue as you explore ways to foster team collaboration and a deeper understanding of conflict; two topics useful as you prepare to work in any team.

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Watch: Why We Work in Teams

Discover how effective teamwork and collaboration can yield innovation.

Video Transcript

The reality is working in teams, it's harder than working alone in most cases. So the question becomes, why do we do it? If the work could be done by ourselves, it probably makes sense to just do it as an individual. But the reality is, when we bring people together, the hope is we're going to create some bigger, better, more effective outcome because of our collaboration. What essentially we're looking to do is to create that one plus one equals greater than two outcome. That our hope is that the difference in our knowledge, in our experience, in our perspectives are different working styles. All of those things come together to create something that none of us could have created on our own.

There's nothing more painful than trying to come together and collaborating and ending up delivering something that's less than any of us could have done on our own; that is a really frustrating experience. But on the flip side, it's amazing to get to that outcome that you are totally sure you never could have come to on your own, but through the synergies of the different perspectives and ideas of members of your team, you get to that breakthrough solution that could have only happened through the power of collaboration. The reality is, in order to get to that amazing outcome, it does take work. We need to figure out how to effectively leverage our differences for the benefit of the team and to explore the differences in ways that get us to unique outcomes. In order to do this, it means a lot of engagement with each other, it means a lot of really good dialogue, and something that sometimes feels uncomfortable but is critical to the success of that one plus one equals greater than two outcome; really good, productive conflict.

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Watch: The Power of Diverse Teams

Ms. Georgianna compares the actual and assumed differences that can be present within a team, and explains why diversity leads to better results.

Video Transcript

The research tells us that the more diverse our teams are, the more potential we have to deliver better results; this is actually because of a couple of reasons. One that seems probably pretty obvious to most of us is that our actual differences, our different backgrounds, our different experiences, our different knowledge sets; those can come together to create a richer, robust set of information and data to use in our work together. But there's another thing that is happening when we are in more diverse teams that in some ways I think is actually the more interesting part of why diverse teams tend to produce better results; that has to do with some things that go on in our brain when we're working with people that are different from us. When we work with those that we perceive are different, a few things happen: We tend to prepare differently for our interactions; we're more rigorous in our preparation work; when we are engaging in sharing our ideas, we do a much better job of advocating our point of view, explaining why we think what we think, and making the case for our perspective; we're also more rigorous in using inquiry to try to more deeply understand the perspectives of others. These more in depth interactions and preparation and whatnot give us much richer data to work with as a team as we're trying to create the best solutions possible.

What happens when we work with people who are the same as us is that, in fact, our brain starts to take shortcuts. We have this inner working; our brains like to be as efficient as possible. When I see you, somebody who is really similar to me or that I perceive as being similar to me sharing an idea, our brain will take a shortcut and say, "Oh, well, you know what? Jennifer is very similar to me and she's thinking this. So you know what? That's probably what I would think, too." We don't do some of the levels of critical thinking that we do when somebody else who we perceive as being different from us is sharing their perspective. Now there's some really interesting research in this space; I'm going to just quickly give you a couple examples.

Dr. Catherine Phillips did a variety of work with groups of students exploring these ideas at Columbia University. She would bring together groups of students and give them a problem to solve. She would prime them either to focus on what they had in common



with each other or what was different about them. She might say, "You know what? I'd like to bring a whole bunch of you that are all a part of the varsity soccer team together to solve this problem," anchoring them in their similarity. Or she might say, "I'd like to bring together student leaders from different groups across campus to try to solve this problem and emphasize the different groups that they were a part of." Consistently, what she found was if she anchored the groups to their similarities, they wouldn't be as rigorous in their thinking processes, and they didn't usually create as strong of solutions as the groups that were anchored to the fact that they were different.

Another interesting piece of data comes from some work that Samuel Summers did with mock juries. He set up a courtroom scenario, and he would put juries together with experts on the case that was being presented observing. In some cases the juries were all white participants; in other cases, the juries included two members who were black. They then presented the case, they would send the juries to deliberate, and they would watch what the deliberations would look like. In the case where there was racial diversity within the mock jury, there was significantly better deliberation, better analysis of the facts. Much more consistently, those juries would come to the conclusion that the experts would say was the more accurate conclusion for the jury to come to. Again, it wasn't necessarily because people on the jury had different information. It wasn't about their different, necessarily, data. But by being in a room with people who are different than us, they would each choose to engage differently than they would have in the other scenario.

Now, in order for all of this to work, I am acknowledging that we do need to actually put greater effort in to maximize the use of these different perspectives. It's the shortcuts that our brain likes to take when we're working with people that are similar to us can feel like it might be more efficient. But the reality is you're losing out on the potential for the innovative solutions that come when you put that greater effort in, when you have more rigor in your engagement with each other. It is through that effort and rigor that we ultimately create the better results. But the one asterisk I'll put on this is in order to get that, we have to have really good team functioning. Otherwise, those differences at times could actually derail us or cause fissures in our relationships. How do we ensure that we do all of the work to collaborate effectively and really maximize these differences towards the results that we're looking for?

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Watch: Drawing Conclusions

How do we arrive at our conclusions? How can we effectively communicate our conclusions with others on our team? Ms. Georgianna introduces the concept of the Ladder of Inference for drawing conclusions.

Video Transcript

Part of the benefit of diverse teams is that we bring different perspectives and experiences and knowledge to the team, and as a result, we come to usually different conclusions. One of the things that can be really helpful as we think about our team and our team effectiveness is to make sure that we really understand how do we arrive at our own conclusions and how can we better understand the conclusions of others. Now, one model that I love in thinking about and understanding how we get to our conclusions is a model called the ladder of inference. This is a model that's been around for quite a while; I've been using it for probably over 20 years, but it's something that has really stuck with me and I have found to be extremely valuable as I try to understand and interact with my conclusions and the conclusions of others.

So what is the ladder of inference? It's a funny model, but I find it to be useful. The idea here of the ladder of inference is that at any given moment in time, there is an infinite pool of data that is available to us to pay attention to. Now, we're not able to function if we tried to factor in every data point that is available to us at any given point in time; we would get completely overwhelmed. I'm sitting here in a studio. But you know what? I haven't paid any attention to what color the rug is or what kind of panels are on the ceiling. Because those were things that were completely irrelevant to what we were trying to do today. My brain has naturally filtered and focused on the important data that was needed in order for me to effectively do what it is that I needed to do here. So in any situation where we are trying to figure out how to solve a problem or or to take on a task, we immediately select certain data that we find important. Once we've selected that data, we then try to figure out, well, what does this data mean; what do I want to interpret about this data? Once we've added that meaning, then we start to make assumptions: Based on that meaning, does that meaning make this data good? Does it make it bad? Does it cause me to assume certain people are going to act in certain ways? Those assumptions then end up forming our conclusions. What we end up deciding is the right answer or the outcome or the way to think about whatever the problem statement is or

the solution we're trying to come up with. Once we've come up with a conclusion, it then usually informs our actions that we take going forward, and it actually usually will inform the filters that our brains use to figure out what's the data that's important to pay attention to going forward.

Source: Senge, Peter M. *The fifth discipline: The art and practice of the learning organization*. Broadway Business, 2006.

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Watch: Creating Collaborative Outcomes

It is not enough for a team to simply be diverse. Ms. Georgianna shares how establishing a shared conclusion through unique perspectives can lead to the most successful teamwork environment.

Video Transcript

When we understand the ladder of inference, it can really help us to see all the points where different thinking can occur. So how if we pay attention to different data or we put different meaning on even the same pieces of data, or come to different assumptions, how easy it is for us to come to really different conclusions; even when we think we're trying to solve the same problem or look at the same challenge. The reality is that our truth is only one truth; that there is no ultimate truth in most of these situations and that other very valid truths exist. The more that we can be aware of that, the more that we can use those differences to our advantage as a team. In situations where I've come to a conclusion and you've come to a very different conclusion, what we need to do is to use advocacy and inquiry to better explore each other's ladders. What do I mean by that? Advocacy is when I'm doing a really nice job of walking you through my ladder. I'm helping you understand, here's the data that I paid attention to, here's the meaning I'm putting on that data. Do I see this data as good or bad, or how does that data then maybe inform what it is that we're thinking about or what we're trying to tackle? What are the assumptions that I might be making based upon that meaning and then ultimately how that all brings me to my conclusion? Similarly, I'm going to want to use inquiry to understand better your ladder.

Often, when we develop a conclusion we haven't necessarily proactively thought about all of the components that got us to that conclusion. Sometimes using really good inquiry and curious questioning can help us to unpack how somebody else has gotten to their conclusion; what the data is that they're paying attention to, and how similar or different is it from the data that we were focused on? What meaning did they put on that data; what assumptions are they making? What are all of these different pieces driving them to their conclusion? In using really good advocacy and inquiry, what we're basically doing is we're moving the conversation down the ladder. In more dysfunctional situations of differing perspectives, we have what we would call conclusion wars, where I have a conclusion and you have a conclusion and I advocate mine and you state yours, and

ultimately we go back and forth until one of us gives up and one of us wins. But that's not why we work together in teams. What we want to do is to move this conversation down, to be curious about the data, the information, the assumptions, the meaning that's underneath the conclusions so that we can ultimately explore each other's perspectives and hopefully actually merge that information so that we're paying attention maybe to the data that I thought was important, the data that you thought was important, that through our conversation, we're coming to some shared understanding of a greater meaning of this data. We're making more informed assumptions and ultimately driving to a third conclusion that was a better conclusion than either of us had come to originally. This is ultimately why we work in teams. We work in teams so that we can create this third shared ladder with conclusions and outcomes that are better than any of us would have come up with on our own.

Source: Senge, Peter M. *The fifth discipline: The art and practice of the learning organization*. Broadway Business, 2006.

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Watch: Constructive Conflict

Disparate viewpoints within teams often bring conflict. Ms. Georgianna illustrates the difference between cool and hot conflict, and how to turn conflict into productive conversations.

Video Transcript

To get to those one plus one is greater than two outcomes, the reality is, as a team we have to have conflict, but we want to make sure is that this is productive conflict, not conflict that ends up creating negative tensions within the team. The idea is we're trying to find what I call sort of the sweet spot between artificial harmony where we're afraid to step on each other's toes, and we're so focused on trying to get along that we're not willing to bring up differing perspectives and ideas, but we obviously don't want to be on the other end of the continuum where we're so aggressive with each other that it feels like we're having mean-spirited attacks and that it gets personal.

What we want ultimately is that healthy place in the middle, where there's unfiltered, passionate discussion about the issues and the content. This dialogue is what's made possible by having deep levels of psychological safety and trust built up within the team over time. Sometimes this type of conflict, the type of conflict that we want on our teams is what we would call cool conflict. Cool conflict emerges when in general we've done a really good job of getting aligned on some shared goals. We all know that when we have differences of opinion, it's in service of the goals that we have set for ourselves. Usually, cool conflict has more data and the ability to explore objectively different perspectives and different interpretations relative to the facts. It's not about individuals, but it's about "This is the data that I'm seeing, this is the data that you're seeing; let's look at that data, let's explore it. Let's see why we're maybe thinking different things are important."

On the other hand, if we're getting to some of that more dysfunctional type of conflict, we're getting to what we would call hot conflict. And where the cool conflict was more task-based, our hot conflict is where it turns relational; often this is where we're having conflict that's not actually about shared goals. Sometimes some of our values or beliefs are feeling challenged, or some of the things that we think are in our best interest are feeling as though they're at risk. Often times, a hot conflict is much more subjective.

Interpretations are harder to test, and that usually there's much more lack of agreement about the interpretation of the situation and it can start to feel personal and that we are



each individually being judged.

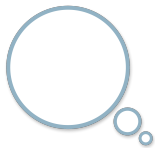
In most cases, hot conflict is not productive for teams, and so one of the things that we want to make sure that we're doing when it starts to feel like it may be getting heated, is figure out how do we keep that conflict cool; how do we bring that conflict back to being conflict that's really productive and helpful for us as a team? There's a couple of things we can focus on to do that: trust and relationship development. The more trust that exists in the team, the more we have established and really set that foundation of trust, the more we're going to interpret the actions of others as not being a personal attack on us. If I trust you and I know that you trust me and we are having differing perspectives on what the next step is to move forward or the solution that we need to move forward with, my default assumptions are going to be that you're working with the best of intentions towards me and the team, and that isn't meant to be a personal attack. Similarly, the more that we invest in our relationships, the more that we can have productive, cool conflict.

What I mean by investing in relationships is on any team, there are certain people who we probably would admit, if we were asked, that we get along with better. They're just very easy to work with, we tend to have similar styles. And then there's other people on the team in most cases, especially when we're trying to create teams that are going to bring different perspectives together, that, you know, we don't always see things the same way. We tend to have different styles or approaches to how we do things, and those are the relationships that we might call are sort of on the fault line. There's they're more likely to have the potential gap between us that could foster hotter conflict happening more quickly. I encourage you to invest in those relationships, really challenge yourself to go deeper with those people, to see them, to get to know them, and the complexity of who they are as human beings. Because, again, the deeper you have that understanding of them, the more you're going to be likely to interpret their difference of opinion, their different perspective in a moment of conflict as something that can be channeled towards cool conflict versus feeling personal and becoming hot conflict.

When we are engaging in conflict, I think the one last thing here on this topic of cool and hot conflict that I'd like you to remember is that it turns out for conflict to occur, there have to be multiple parties involved. I mean, yes, we all do sometimes argue with ourselves and debate different perspectives, but in general, you need to have multiple parties in any of these moments of team conflict. What I'm going to ask you to do is to recognize that there is no conflict that doesn't have some level of responsibility in it from every party that's involved. I used to work with a woman who ran the R&D organization for a firm that I worked in, and one day I walked into her office and in the corner of her whiteboard she had a quote and it said, "The one common element of every one of my

dysfunctional relationships is me." I chuckled and I asked her, I said, "You know what? What's going on with this with this quote on your board?" She said, "We were having a senior staff meeting and there was a whole lot of complaining about what marketing was doing and what finance was doing and sales was doing. And I said, time out a minute. You know what? The reality is, yes, there might be things that we're wanting other groups to be doing differently or different perspectives that we might want them to appreciate, but the reality is we're a part of this relationship, and we need to make sure that we're also owning the pieces of this that might be causing them to be frustrated with us or for them to be seeing us as being the one who's causing things to be challenging."

I ask you, when you are in a moment of conflict, especially if it's starting to get hot, can you pause for a minute and be really honest with yourself about what is your contribution here and how can you shift your contribution to being a productive one where this conflict can actually help you as a team to get to better outcomes versus something that might derail you or cause you to have setbacks as a team.



Consider This

Do you typically engage in cool or hot conflict? What is the outcome?

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Watch: Handling Conflict

How is conflict typically handled in teams? Here, Ms. Georgianna introduces a model that attempts to answer this question. The goal is to use conflict productively in your team to get the best outcome.

Video Transcript

How we each handle moments of conflict tends to differ based on various perspectives, habits, and norms that we've developed over time. It's interesting. For many of us these preferences around how we handle conflict are actually formed at really early ages. We learn from those around us: our families, our educational systems, our cultures; what are acceptable ways of handling conflict, and we bring those forward with us into adulthood. The challenge is that these default preferences don't always match with the ideal approach to conflict in a given situation. Sometimes we use our default preference in a time when a better approach to conflict might be something totally different. So our opportunity, if we're going to be working in teams, is to develop a deeper awareness of what our own individual preferences are and then figure out how can we be more deliberate in ensuring we're actually applying the right conflict approach to the situation, even if it's not our preferred or default approach?

Let's look at some different styles of conflict using the Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Modes model. In this model there are two axes that indicate in anchor the type of approach that we're taking, and it has to do with whose concerns we're paying attention to. If we are paying attention significantly more to our own concerns and making sure that our own concerns and needs are met, then we're going to be higher on the assertiveness scale. If we're really paying attention to making sure that the other person's concerns are met, we're going to be farther along on the cooperativeness scale. As you can see, depending on where we fall on those, there's five different approaches that we may take to a conflict. The first might be let's start with competing. If I'm really focused on making sure my concerns are met, I'm going to advocate really strongly and it's going to be hard to sway me from my perspective.

One of the times that competing can be very helpful is say there's something that I perceive as an ethical dilemma, and I feel as though actually, if we meet your concerns, we may be swaying off of something that feels ethically okay to me. Then I'm going to choose competing and make sure that I really fight for us to make what I believe is the



right choice. On the flip side, I might say that, you know what? We each have a concern in a certain scenario, but it seems as though yours is more important to you and mine, you know what? I could go either way. I might then choose accommodating and let you have your concerns met in this moment in time, and hope that maybe some of my concerns in a situation that feels more important to me will be met in the future. Often when we have different concerns, we will default to trying to find a compromise where part of my concerns are met and part of your concerns are met. This can be great, it can be a little bit more time efficient than going to collaborating, which we'll talk about in a minute. The one risk though that you want to be careful of is that we don't in the process of this lose the most important parts of each of our concerns and as a result, neither feel satisfied with the outcome.

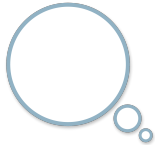
In situations where we have really important decisions to be made, conflicts to be resolved that are going to have far-reaching effects for us going forward and or if we really have enough time for it, collaborating can be a great choice. When we're collaborating, we're putting in the time, we're doing the effort to really find a way to get creative and address both of our concerns simultaneously. The reality though is, we can't always collaborate. Either it's not going to be the right mode relative to what would be the time investment, given the importance of the outcome, or even if we would love to in an ideal state, we may have other constraints that just won't allow it. The fifth is avoiding. And avoiding is when we look at a situation, and we say, you know what, we're actually not going to address this conflict at all and neither of our concerns are going to be met. This is a situation where at times avoiding is really the appropriate choice, especially if we're having a conflict in a moment where time is tight, maybe we're in the middle of a presentation in front of other people; this isn't going to be the moment to have our conflict emerge.

The thing we want to caution ourselves with avoiding is usually we might avoid it in the moment, but it might be helpful to come back and discuss it at a later time. If we do too much avoiding over time, it can build up and resentment can occur and other things that can cause us to blow up and end up in a hot conflict because we didn't address a whole bunch of smaller cool conflicts along the way. What I would say is, as you're thinking as a team about how you're going to handle conflict and how you're going to really use conflict productively in your team, it can be helpful in moments of conflict to pause and actually be curious about, what's the right conflict mode in this moment for us or what's the right conflict mode I want to take to help us to get to the best outcome? The more



strategic we can be about that versus defaulting to our own individual preferences, the more likely we're going to be to get the types of results out of our conflict that we want when we're working together in a team.

Source: Thomas, Kenneth Wayne, and Ralph H. Kilmann. *Thomas-Kilmann conflict mode instrument: Profile and interpretive report*. CPP, Incorporated, 2008.



Consider This

What approach in the Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Modes model do you typically use when working with others?

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Tool: Conflict Styles

Conflict can be good if handled correctly.

Use this tool as a reference to help you identify your own conflict style and the style of those you work with. Be playful in managing conflict in your team and in creating a space where collaboration can occur. Remember, the key is to debate the issue and not the people.

Download this document for future reference.

 [Download the Tool](#)

Use this helpful tool [Conflict Styles](#) to identify and manage conflict in your teams.

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Journal — Fostering Collaboration

Using the same Reflection Journal document you downloaded in the first module, open and complete the third set of questions.

Directions:

- Complete the Fostering Collaboration boxes on page three
- Write in short, readable bullet points
- Quickly reference them later on

Important instructions for saving your work:

When you open the linked PDF, it may open in a new browser window. Save it to your desktop or preferred storage location, then open it with Adobe Reader, and save a copy with a new name. This will give you a working copy that you can review, print, or add content to without losing your work. It will also enable you to retain a clean copy of the original document for future use.

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Download the Tool

Use the same **Reflection Journal** to prepare for productive conflict and collaborative team dialogue.



Module Wrap-up: **Foster Collaboration**

This module focused on the advantages of working in diverse teams and the innovative solutions that it can produce. You studied the Ladder of Inference, a model that illustrates how different data is considered in order to draw different conclusions. Laura Georgianna explained how advocacy and inquiry are used to explore one another's ladders and to develop shared understanding. When your teams engage in constructive and healthy conflict, you can arrive at better decisions and outcomes. In your reflection journal, you explored your own conflict preferences to foster productive conflict and collaborative dialog within your team.

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Module Introduction: **Drive Action**



How do teams make decisions? How much engagement is needed among team members to lead to action? Ms. Laura Georgianna helps you to discover your own decision making style and that of your teammates. You will compare various approaches to decision making and how various perspectives work for the broader team. You will discover how

roles and responsibilities can reduce frustration and facilitate relationships. In your reflection journal, you will examine your decision making skills and how you manage accountability; both for yourself and for others.

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Watch: Decision Making Norms

Different decision making styles can cause tension or be a great benefit to teams depending upon how the differences are handled. Ms. Georgianna shares a simple decision making framework to illustrate different decision making styles that may be present in your teams.

Video Transcript

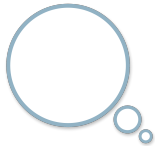
One of the big challenges that can occur for many teams is how to actually move to action, how to approach making decisions as a collective group. One of the things that can be helpful is to have an awareness of some of our own preferences and the preferences of others in our team as to how we like to make decisions so that we can factor that in as we are trying to progress in the work that we're doing towards our goals. One framework or concept around decision making that I find really helpful to be aware of is one that we'll call big-d or little-d decision making.

Now, let me take a minute to explain to you what I mean by big-d and little-d. If you tend to have a preference towards being a big-d decision maker, what this means is that you like to make sure that all of the data has been looked at and analyzed and that all the key stakeholders have had a chance to weigh in and be a part of the decision making. Then ultimately, once you have all that information and you make the decision, you usually pretty much consider that decision to be final, and it's going to be very hard to get you to pivot off of that decision once it has been made. Your focus is now going to be fully on executing based on that decision.

If, on the other hand, you tend to be a little bit more of what we would call a little-d decision maker, what this is, is people who are much more comfortable creating outcomes and decisions on less information and maybe even less stakeholder input, partially because they're much more comfortable being fluid with these decisions and if new information comes along or a stakeholder brings up an idea or a factor that hadn't been considered previously, somebody who is a more of a small d decision maker is going to feel much more comfortable pivoting and changing that decision and iterating on the decision as the work is getting done and as the team is executing towards their results.

What's interesting is to be aware of what your own decision making style is, be aware of the decision making styles of others on the team, and then figure out what that means

for how you want to make decisions going forward. It can be tricky if, say, all of us are big-d decision makers because we can get stuck in the analysis paralysis side of things, where there's never enough data to be really comfortable that we're making the decision. The other challenge can be if we're all little-d decision makers, we can be really quick to execute and to make decisions but we may miss important information because we're moving so fast. If we can be aware of these differences and actually use them as a benefit to ourselves, if we have a bit of a mix, it can create a nice balance for us as a team where some are going to push for more data, more connection of incorporating different people's ideas and stakeholder perspectives, and others are going to push us to move, recognizing that maybe down the road we'll have to make some adjustments. If we can find the way to create a balance across these different approaches, it can actually really be a great competitive advantage for us in our teams.



Consider This

What do you consider to be your own decision making style? Are you a "big-D" or a "little-d" decision maker?

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Watch: Approaches to Decision Making

How can you apply the best decision making approach to the type of decision the team is making? Ms. Georgianna explains different approaches and how to use the right one for various situations.

Video Transcript

One of the things we want to do as we are making decisions in our teams is to try to optimize our decision making approach to the type of decision that we're making. The higher the level of quality that might be required of the decision and the greater the level of acceptance from key stakeholders that might be required, the more time we're going to want to spend on working on the decision, and the more engagement of others we're going to want to facilitate. Now, we want to be careful because we don't want to overburden our team with really in-depth decision making processes for what could be considered really simple tactical decisions. Similar to other team structures and processes, we want to match the process to the task to really create sort of an optimal efficiency and effectiveness for us as a team. Let's say we have a fairly tactical decision that isn't going to have long reaching effects for us as a team. We can probably take what we would call a directive approach, where essentially you as the leader just makes the decision without really consulting anybody else and just informs them of what the decision is. This could be something as simple as, "Okay, when are we going to meet next?" Probably you can — if you have general information about the team — make the decision and let everybody know when and where that next meeting is going to occur.

Now, let's say we'll move along this continuum a little bit to slightly more complex decisions. There may be situations where there's somebody in the team who has certain capacity available to them or a certain expertise, and it might make sense to actually just delegate the decision as the leader or to another member of the team. So you might be able to give that decision to another teammate and that they will essentially, on their own, be able to make the decision on behalf of the team. If we move even further along as the decisions maybe get slightly more important, where we need more engagement, we need to ensure a higher level of quality outcome, we may choose a consultation approach. And the consultation approach is where, as the leader, I may be seeking input from others on the team or outside of the team to inform the decision; but ultimately in the end, I'm going to make the decision. Continuing along, we can get to a place of

choosing to make what we would call democratic decisions, where we're really looking to get the perspective from all the different members of the team, get their input, get their ideas, weigh differing considerations that different team members may bring up. Then ultimately look at what is the majority opinion of the group and making the decision based upon what the majority of people are indicating that they believe is the best path forward for the decision.

Now, one little caveat I'd like to pause and emphasize here is that for this democratic decision making process to work effectively, we do need to make sure that we take the time for discussion upfront before deciding how to proceed. I've seen teams at times go right to, "Okay, let's take a vote and see whether we should do A or B," without having had the dialogue about what the pros and cons are of some of the different options. If we move too quickly to trying to identify the majority opinion, those sometimes who maybe are in the minority opinion will feel as though they weren't necessarily heard or considered prior to the decision being made. We want to make sure that we give people a chance to have voice and to truly be heard and considered so that that sense of contribution and value of contribution is showing up there. By doing so, you're much more likely to get the individuals who had the minority perspective to ultimately end up coming on board with the decision that's being made and committing to it, whether they agree or potentially disagree with what that end outcome ended up being.

Now, for our most important critical decisions, where high quality and a lot of alignment and acceptance across the team is really important, we may want to spend the time trying to really build full consensus. Now, full consensus is where we are facilitating the process of trying to get everyone on the team in full agreement. This can be challenging when there are significantly different perspectives, but there are certain moments, especially in decisions that are then going to have long reaching impact to other decisions and other ways that the team is working together. Times like that, it may be worth really emphasizing and focusing on the work that it takes to get to full consensus.

Now as you're thinking about these different decision making approaches and trying to find which one is the right match, for my specific task that's at hand as a leader, we want to be careful to recognize that something that might feel really tactical to us or fairly low stakes could feel like a very important decision to another member of the team. So the process of deciding which decision making approach to use, with some perspective taking to ensure that you're also considering the perspectives of others on the team to inform that, can help you to ensure that you're choosing a decision making approach

that's going to really work for the broader team to help you to be most effective and aligned, as well as efficient in your process of trying to move towards decisions and ultimately towards action.

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Watch: Role Clarity in Teams

Assigning clear roles and responsibilities will go a long way to reduce frustration while also helping to build relationships, as Ms. Georgianna explains.

Video Transcript

When working in teams, it can be helpful to ensure that we have different people playing different roles and having different responsibilities such that we're moving forward in a smooth process with executing on our tasks. Now sometimes some of these roles and responsibilities get taken by different team members organically and it sort of happens naturally. But it's important as we work together as a team to pause and be reflective throughout our time together to make sure that some of the key types of roles that are needed for us to deliver our results are actually happening. These are roles such as we may need somebody to be a bit of a timekeeper to help to facilitate us through our agenda and make sure that we're making progress. In other cases, we may need to make sure that there's somebody taking some sort of notes and recording the decisions that are being made in our time together. Other teams may find that it's helpful to have a role such as a devil's advocate if we are all agreeing with each other and need to have some structures to push out our ideas and really make sure that we're being rigorous in our analysis as we're trying to make decisions about how to proceed. What I would encourage is for you in your teams to either be proactive in identifying some of these roles or to observe your interactions and see whether or not the roles are starting to happen naturally. One thing I also do encourage is that you pay attention to whether or not the same people are playing the same role on the team, day to day, meeting to meeting, and whether or not that's working for you as a team or whether it might be beneficial to actually rotate roles. I know that personally for me, when it's my turn to be the note taker, I have trouble multitasking between being the note taker and being an active contributor and sharing my ideas. And so if the same person is constantly the note taker, you want to be careful of the fact that you may be missing some of their key contributions. So having proactive dialogue about how you want to manage these roles can be really helpful to your team effectiveness and really driving your team forward to action.

Another thing that can be helpful as we think about roles and we think about driving action is the processes to make sure that we're organizing the work that is happening



outside of our meetings. So it's not uncommon — and I'm sure you've all been in these sorts of meetings, right, where we talk about a whole lot of things. And then all of a sudden we look and we realize, "Oh, we're out of time," and we close up the meeting because we have to run to our next thing and we never close the loop on what was going to get done before our next meeting and who exactly was going to be doing that work. One of the best practices I would recommend that you consider when working in teams is to really be diligent about reserving, say, your last five minutes of the meeting to really organize these next steps. An easy tool for this that you could use that I learned actually from one of my students a number of years ago that they used in his organization was WWWF. And that has nothing to do with wrestling,

I don't know how many w's the wrestling version of this has, but this is really about the idea of using that last five minutes of your meeting to be very clear on who is responsible to do something: What exactly is it that they're responsible to do? When is it that we're expecting this thing to be done? And how are we going to follow up with each other to ensure that completion of the tasks that are assigned to us are being completed? What's interesting is that by being explicit about these things, not only does it help us with forward momentum and making sure that the tasks that we want to have happen are happening between our meetings. But I would argue that being explicit about these is actually really helpful for our team relations and our interpersonal dynamics. When we're not explicit about this, we leave meetings with a whole lot of assumptions that are not necessarily aligned assumptions between team members. I might be thinking you're going to take a first pass at building the financial model for the project we're working on and you may be envisioning that another team member is supposed to be doing that. This lack of clarity will cause us to get to a point where I'm frustrated because I thought you were supposed to deliver this model to the rest of the team, and you're waiting for somebody else to do it right. Then we start to get all sorts of opinions and perspectives about who's committed to the team, their level of organization, and whatnot. The more we can be clear about this, it'll help us drive to action, but it'll also help our relationships and our understanding and appreciation for each other and our contributions.

Try the WWWF Tool:

- **W**ho is responsible?
- **W**hat are they responsible for?
- **W**hen does it need to be done?
- How will we **F**ollow-up to ensure completion?

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Journal — Driving Action

Using the same Reflection Journal document you downloaded in the first module, open and complete the fourth set of questions.

Directions:

- Complete the Driving Action boxes on page four
- Write in short readable bullet points
- Quickly reference them later on

Important instructions for saving your work:

When you open the linked PDF, it may open in a new browser window. Save it to your desktop or preferred storage location, then open it with Adobe Reader, and save a copy with a new name. This will give you a working copy that you can review, print, or add content to without losing your work. It will also enable you to retain a clean copy of the original document for future use.

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 **Download the Tool**

Use the same **Reflection Journal** to identify and increase the decision making effectiveness of your team.

Module Wrap-up: Drive Action

In this module, you explored how you can enable team accountability and effective decision making. Laura Georgianna compared big-d and little-d decision makers, and how firm or flexible they are. A variety of decision making approaches were demonstrated, from directive to consensus, and how being a part of this process enables team members to feel valued. You saw it is possible to drive group action by having proactive conversations around specific roles and responsibilities. Continuing with your journal, you examined your tendencies for making decisions and managing accountability.

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Module Introduction: **Learn for Continuous Improvement**



Closing out Team Dynamics, Ms. Laura Georgianna emphasizes the importance of getting the most out of your team for your own growth and personal development. You will identify how to design goals that you can commit to. You will see ways to incorporate reviews and feedback into your processes for continuous improvement. And in the final entry of your reflection journal, you will create an initial development goal that you wish to address for your growth and that of your team.

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Watch: Leveraging Team Experiences for Personal Development

What makes team environments one of the best places for personal growth? Ms. Georgianna explains how to get the most out of teamwork through the SMART goals technique and feedback.

Video Transcript

The research tells us that team environments are actually one of the best places for personal development and growth. That the process of actually partnering with your team on your growth and development is part of the secret to that success. There's a few things that we need to do in order to be able to get the most out of this team context for our personal development. The first is that we need to design our goals for personal development really well, and make sure that we write them down. When we write them down, that's actually when they come to life for us, we start to essentially establish our commitment to that goal, and as a result, start to behave towards it.

Now, when I talk about this idea of designing a goal, one of the things that we can use to do that is the tool of writing what we would call SMART goals. Now, some of you may be familiar with SMART goals; this is a structure that a lot of organizations use to encourage their people to make their goals really actionable. I always joke that I hate actually writing SMART goals, but I love having a SMART goal. Writing SMART goals can be tough because we have to actually really dig into what is it that we're in fact trying to change: What does it look like to do that and to do that well?

Let's talk through the different components of what makes a really good SMART goal. The first is that the goal needs to be specific: We need to have enough detail about the who, what, where, when, why elements of our goal, so that it's tangible. The second piece, the M stands for measurable. We want to create enough specificity and making it as quantifiable as possible that we can know if we're making any progress. It's really helpful to be able to see progress as a motivator to continue striving towards your goal; having some measures is very important. We want it to be achievable: If you pick a goal to work on in your team, that's really never going to the platform to work on, it's never going to show up in the team, it's just going to become frustrating. Because you're not going to have a chance to apply what it is you're trying to work on. We want to make sure that we're really realistic about the goal that we're picking, and that we have what we need



within our team context to be able to attain it.

The R in smart stands for relevant. We want to ensure that this goal is relevant to us, to our larger set of maybe career goals, our larger mission, to our larger purpose. Why is it important to us to actually develop in the way that we're setting in this goal? We want to make sure that the goal feels like it's worth doing. Because it turns out behavior change is hard. If we don't see an importance, we don't see a relevance to building the skills that we're trying to build, it's going to be much harder to be motivated to do it. The last is time-bound. We want to set some milestones, some progress plan that helps us to anchor to making progress within the goal. Now, when we work in a team, sometimes that can naturally tie to key milestones in the work that the team is doing. Or it may be that this team is together for a period of time, so your time-bound element is that I want to to achieve this goal by the time that this team disbands. There can be many different types of ways that you set timelines on the goals, but you want to make sure that you have some time structure associated with it.

Now, when we've created these goals, the other pieces of the research inform us that we want to make sure that we're sharing these goals with the other members of our team. When we tell people that we respect and who we know will see us in action trying to work on these goals, when we tell them our goals we're much more likely to actually then deliver. We're much more likely to try to act on it because we see a different level of accountability for ourselves; we attempt to make the change. We also need to be explicit in giving these people who are going to observe us in action permission to help us, and explain exactly how we want their help. Do we want them to call us out if we're not doing what we said we were going to do in the moment in the meeting? Do we want them to pull us aside one on one and maybe give us a little bit of coaching? Those are things that if we tell people and we give them permission, they're going to be much more likely to engage with us on helping us with our goals. We also want to make sure that we're asking those observing us to provide us with specific feedback on how we're doing relative to our progress. Now, the reality is, as I mentioned earlier, behavior change is hard. But with putting some of these structures in place, you're going to be significantly more likely to make progress on your goals within the team based context.

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Tool: Designing SMART Goals

Writing and committing to goals are important for your personal growth, and designing SMART goals is a great way to make your goals actionable. To design a SMART goal, you will need to really dig into *what* exactly it is you want to change and *how* to do it well. Achieving your goals is more likely when you:

- Write them down
- Design them well i.e., SMART
- Share them with others
- Give others permission to help and explain how
- Ask others for feedback

Download this document for future reference.

Important instructions for saving your work:

When you open the linked PDF, it may open in a new browser window. Save it to your desktop or preferred storage location, then open it with Adobe Reader, and save a copy with a new name. This will give you a working copy that you can review, print, or add content to without losing your work. It will also enable you to retain a clean copy of the original document for future use.

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Download the Tool

Use this tool **Designing SMART Goals** to help you draft your own SMART goals.



Watch: Iterative Improvement in Teams

Personal and team growth is an iterative journey. Ms. Georgianna presents a simple tool to evaluate how to improve both as a team and individually.

Video Transcript

As a collective team, we want to make sure that in our time working together, we're learning and growing and evolving as a team, that we're increasing our overall effectiveness through an iterative process of growth. Now there's a quote that some people say came from Albert Einstein, which is "Insanity is doing the same thing over and over again and expecting different results." When I see teams do this, it's one of the things that drives me the most crazy. When I talk to a team and I say, "How did your meeting with the client go?" They say, "Well, it wasn't great, but I'm hoping the next one will be better." Without doing some proactive work to identify what's working and what's not working, the likelihood is you're going to continue to get the same results.

A simple tool that you can use that can really help to ensure that as a team, you're learning from your experiences and you're really advancing your overall effectiveness, is a tool called the After Action Review. Now, the after action review originated as a military tool, but over time it's been incorporated into many organizational processes outside of just a military context. There are many versions of this tool, but essentially there are four components that are at least at the heart of most after action reviews. The idea is that we start by having a conversation that explores what did we want to have happen; what was it that actually happened; why did that happen — why did we get the results that we did; then what do we want to do the same or differently going forward based upon the observations we have of what we were able to achieve relative to what we had hoped to achieve? By being able to do this, we can have significantly further insight that can help us to iterate our work together as a team.

Now, in having this after action review conversation, there are a few best practices that we want to focus on, one of which is immediacy. If we have key milestone moments where we are delivering certain intensive specific things as a team, right after those can be a really helpful point to do an after action review. Where we can say, you know what, we just had that client meeting. What do we want to have happen in that meeting? What happened? Why did we get those results that we got right? Then, what do we want to do differently for the next client meeting? What do we want to do the same for the next

client meeting? How can we iterate to increase our performance in the next interaction? It's also helpful to designate somebody to be the facilitator of the after action review. They can help to move the conversation along, they can also make sure that all voices are heard because it's very important that everybody participate when we are doing after action reviews and so you get the benefit of everyone's contribution, but they're also feeling connected to the outcomes of the team. Part of how that happens — that connection, that sense of contribution — is through ensuring that you're also really creating a very psychologically safe space for your after action review, where people can feel as though it's okay to highlight something that we could have done better or differently and that's actually in benefit and in service of the team versus being perceived as somehow being critical of each other or the team overall.

One recommendation that I will make is that sometimes in an after action review, you can come out with a whole lot of things that you would like to do differently. The reality is that for most of us, we can only execute on a couple of changes at a time, especially if any of them are behavior changes that we want to engage in. What I would say is pick just a couple key actions that you want to do differently, focus on those, and then maybe in your next after action review, pick a couple more. But don't overwhelm yourselves with the amount of change that you want to put in place as a team. If you're able to be consistent in building a cadence of doing after action reviews after each of your key milestones, what you'll find is that you'll start to perform naturally better as a team. You will actually deepen the connection and the interdependence of the team members to help you also with these outcomes. I will tell you why: I have watched teams that are essentially doing very similar tasks, some of which get into a really good cadence with an after action review and others of which don't. The teams that get into the really good cadence of after action reviews on a regular cycle after key milestones significantly increase their team effectiveness, their overall performance, and their overall satisfaction of being a part of the team. I really encourage you to think about how to build these practices into your work as a team.

Conduct an After Action review in your team:

- What did we want to have happen?
- What happened?
- Why did that happen?
- What do we want to do going forward?

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Tool: Facilitate an After Action Review

Incorporating an After Action Review after key milestones will help to increase team effectiveness, overall performance, and satisfaction in being a part of the team.

Download this document for future reference.

 **Download the Tool**

Use this helpful **Facilitate an After Action Review** tool to lead a discussion after key milestones.

Important instructions for saving your work:

When you open the linked PDF, it may open in a new browser window. Save it to your desktop or preferred storage location, then open it with Adobe Reader, and save a copy with a new name. This will give you a working copy that you can review, print, or add content to without losing your work. It will also enable you to retain a clean copy of the original document for future use.

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Watch: Giving and Receiving Feedback

Feedback can be used to help individuals and the team grow. Ms. Georgianna shares several important tips for giving and receiving constructive feedback within a team.

Video Transcript

Whether it's related to a development goal, a team after action review, or really any other type of interpersonal reaction on the team, your ability to both give and to receive feedback really well ends up being critical to individual as well as overall team performance. One of the keys to being able to do really good feedback is picking the right type of feedback for the moment. Most all feedback, if we look at it and analyzed it, can be categorized into one of three types of feedback: appreciation feedback, coaching feedback or evaluation feedback.

Let's take a minute and talk about appreciation feedback. Appreciation feedback is essentially when we observe that somebody is making progress or we see some behaviors from them that we want to really reinforce, that is a great scenario within which to give appreciation feedback. Appreciation feedback tends to sound like, "Boy, when you were doing that presentation, the way that you explained the data that we were looking at was done so well and so clearly I could see that everyone in the room was following along and that was a really great job. I'd encourage you to take a similar approach when you're having to explain data in the future, because that was great." Now appreciation feedback tends to be really helpful and useful in situations where maybe somebody has really gone above and beyond, and you want to make sure you're acknowledging that or you know that somebody was stretching themselves a little bit and you saw really good progress in that stretch, and you want to be sharing some feedback that helps them to know that they're doing a great job.

If we move to coaching feedback, coaching feedback tends to be a bouncing opposite in some ways to appreciation feedback where we share coaching feedback, we see opportunities for people to grow and to learn new skills. If I give an example somewhat similar maybe to the appreciation feedback, but on the other side, "I might say, you know what, in that presentation you were doing, I thought it was great that you used storytelling to emphasize the point. I didn't notice when you were telling your story that it got a little long and you wandered a little bit into some additional detail and context that probably wasn't really relevant and it seemed as though we maybe lost a few people in

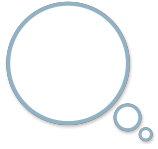
the audience while you were telling the story. So I think using storytelling is really good, but it might be helpful in the future to practice the story a few times and make sure that you get it really tight so that the story emphasizes the point that you're trying to make and doesn't dilute from the larger presentation." Coaching feedback tends to be really useful and valuable, especially when you know that somebody is trying to grow in a certain area. When we have a gap, when we know that we're stretching ourselves, we know we're not going to get it right all the time and the way that we're going to close that gap more quickly is through really good, specific coaching feedback from the people who are observing us and want to help us to develop and grow.

The third type of feedback is evaluation feedback. Now, evaluation feedback tends to be helpful when we have some a goal that we are striving towards, some bar that we're trying to achieve, and we want to know how close are we. Evaluation feedback happens in the classroom all the time; every grade you receive from a faculty member is essentially evaluation feedback. There was a certain bar for the assignment and your grade tells you how close you got to that. In the workplace, evaluation feedback can be how you're doing relative to the expectations of the job that you're in, or maybe you're looking for a promotion and you want evaluation feedback to let you know how close am I to being able to be considered for that promotion. We want to make sure that we are paying attention to when someone does have some an objective criteria that they're measuring themselves against, that we can give them really good evaluation feedback that lets them know how close they are and what they might need to do in order to further close that gap.

Part of the key to giving really good feedback is matching the feedback that we're providing to the type of feedback that is being sought in that moment from the person who's receiving feedback. If I just stayed up all night long trying to work on our presentation to be ready for a meeting with a client and you decide that, bleary-eyed as I am, that this is the moment to give me a bunch of coaching feedback of all the things I could have done better on the presentation, the likelihood is I'm not going to be in the mood in that moment to receive it and your feedback is probably going to fall on deaf ears. That's probably the moment where I'm really looking for the appreciation feedback. If you can use that moment to say, "You know what? I'm sure the rest of the team feels this way as well, but I really appreciate all the work that you put into this presentation last night. We are in a much better place today to be ready to deliver this content to our client than we would have otherwise." If you have some coaching feedback, it's not that you don't want to give it, but you might want to give it at a later point. Let them get a good night's sleep, talk to them in a day or two and be able to share, "I was reflecting on the work we did on that presentation, and I think there's a couple of things that might have



been able to make it more efficient if you'd done some other things and maybe addressed it differently such that we didn't have to pull the all-nighter." Those conversations are important to have, but we want to make sure we're doing the right matching, so that the feedback can be really heard and be utilized to help individuals and to help the team to grow.



Consider This

What type of feedback have you typically given and received?

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Watch: Delivering and Seeking High Quality Feedback

How can you structure feedback in a way that is clear and actionable? Ms. Georgianna provides an efficient way to both give and receive feedback using neutral language.

Video Transcript

When we're engaging in giving feedback, it's really important that we structure the feedback that we're sharing in a way that it can be actionable. A great tool to help us with this is SBIR. SBIR stands for Situation, Behavior, Impact, and Request. Now when we use this tool as a giver of feedback, using it can help us to have the other person put themselves back into the situation that the feedback is associated with. We then can share with them what the behaviors were that we observed and what the impact of those behaviors were on us, the giver of this feedback. By doing this, it can help them to have a clearer understanding of the situation, the scenario, and how we saw it from our perspective. The R portion allows us to have a space to make our request for what it is that we would like them as the feedback receiver to do the same or differently going forward.

Let me share an example. Let's say we came out of a team meeting and I'm feeling a little bit frustrated about how one of the other teammates was interacting with me during the meeting. I might pull that person aside and say, "In the discussion where we were brainstorming ideas, there were three different times when I was trying to share an idea and you interrupted me. It felt as though my voice wasn't being valued and as a result, I ended up just disengaging and not contributing more ideas. I really want to be an active member of this team and so I'd request that, can you keep an eye on making sure that when I'm sharing my ideas, you pause for a moment and you allow me to get my whole idea out and for the group to react to my idea before moving us along to other ideas and content." By sharing that level of specificity in our feedback, the person on the other side is able to see themselves in that situation and to be able to hear more clearly the impact of their behaviors on us as another member of the team and what it is that would be helpful from our perspective for them to do differently going forward.

What's interesting is, we often think about tools like this as being very focused on how do we give feedback. But the reality is we can use tools like this also to make sure we're receiving feedback that is valuable to us. We can't control how somebody else gives us feedback if we just sit and wait for it, but it turns out, we can shape the scenario, shape

the request so that we can get feedback from people that is more meaningful. What do I mean by that? Maybe I'm interested in somebody's perspective on how I did during a presentation. I can say to them, "How do you think that presentation went?" What I'll probably get back is, "I think it was great." Doesn't give me a lot to action with but if I instead say, "During the presentation when I was explaining our position on X, I looked around the room and I felt I saw a few confused faces. What might have been some things that I could have done differently during that part of the presentation that would have helped me to be clearer in the description that I was doing?" By asking for feedback about a very specific situation and explaining what it is that you're looking for, you're going to be much more likely to get the type of feedback that is actionable for you if you're truly looking for it as a growth opportunity.

Now when we're using models like this, when we're giving really any feedback, we want to make sure that we're also using neutral language that's judgment free. Our assumptions about why somebody may be behaving the way they are, or in fact that, they're assumptions. We want to be careful about layering those in at the front end of the feedback because it will automatically put the other person on the defensive. Instead of saying, "It seemed as though you were disengaged in our meeting, we can say, I noticed that you were quiet in the meeting." Quiet is the behavior, disengaged is an assumption about why you are being quiet, and it changes the conversation associated with your feedback dramatically.

If we're able to use neutral language, then the piece of feedback will often turn into a productive discussion. I might be asking you about why you were quiet in the meeting and you might actually also have some feedback then for me or other team members about it, and/or you may be able to then clarify your lack of contribution in a way that helps to really shape for me a very different opinion or perspective about what your contribution was in that moment. I might have been quiet because I felt as though the ideas that others were putting out were great and there wasn't necessarily a need for me to jump in and throw in more ideas because I was supportive of what was being said. Or it might be that, I was feeling really distracted because there's something going on in my personal life and I wasn't focused. It could be a range of 100 different reasons as to why my behavior was what it was, but if I know from you that you noticed it, that you saw an impact to it, maybe you wanted to hear more from me because you value my contributions, then we can have a very different conversation about the request, the R part of the feedback and what needs to happen going forward. I encourage you to think about specificity, context, and requests as you are putting together feedback for individuals or collectively for your team because it will make the feedback more powerful, it will make the feedback more actionable, and

ultimately it will help your team as individuals and collectively to grow.

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Activity: Using the SBIR Model

For feedback to be valuable, it needs to be actionable. Using **SBIR** as the frame behind the feedback you provide or your request for feedback will enable the feedback to be relevant and useful, and will make it more likely to spur positive action by the individual receiving it. Expand each section to learn more.

SBIR Model

▼ Situation

Be clear on the interactions the feedback is based on so the receiver can picture the context.

▼ Behavior

Use neutral descriptors to describe the behavior. Use judgment-free language and avoid loaded words.

- E.g., "quiet" instead of "disengaged," "late" instead of "disrespectful of the team's time."

▼ Impact

How the behavior impacted you, the feedback giver: "When you are late, it makes me feel as though our team is not a priority to you."

- No blanket statements, i.e., "we feel"
- No inferring how others felt, i.e., "I think you made Keith feel..."

▼ Request

Start, Stop, Continue. Again, without judgment: "Strive to be no more than five minutes late. If it will be more, text to let us know," instead of "Start respecting our time and don't be more than five minutes late."

Though this ungraded activity does not require formal submission, this will help you prepare for working with your capstone team.

Directions:

Think about a piece of feedback you would like to give to someone based on a recent interaction or observation. Grab a pen and paper or Word document and use the SBIR model to help you craft high quality feedback:



1. Describe the **situation**; the setting for the feedback
2. Describe the **behavior** you observed; what happened
3. Describe the **impact** of the behavior on you; how it made you feel, think, and act
4. Outline the **request** you have for the feedback receiver's future actions

Now put it all together and review. How is this the same or different from what the feedback would have looked like if you had drafted it without a model? For most of us, the SBIR framework helps us create feedback that is more easily understood, and able to be acted upon by the person receiving it.

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Journal — Learning for Continuous Improvement

Using the same Reflection Journal document you downloaded in the first module, open and complete the final set of questions. You will have a completed individual reflection journal to take to the launch of your capstone team.

 **Download the Tool**

Use the **Reflection Journal** to design a SMART goal and implement a review and feedback process between team members.

Directions:

- Complete the Learning for Continuous Improvement boxes on page five
- Write in short readable bullet points
- Quickly reference them later on

Important instructions for saving your work:

When you open the linked PDF, it may open in a new browser window. Save it to your desktop or preferred storage location, then open it with Adobe Reader, and save a copy with a new name. This will give you a working copy that you can review, print, or add content to without losing your work. It will also enable you to retain a clean copy of the original document for future use.

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Module Wrap-up: **Learn for Continuous Improvement**

The ability to learn for continuous improvement, by designing and setting goals, is key to your success and that of your team. Laura Georgianna articulated how to write SMART goals; specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound. It was shared how conducting an after action review will help you iterate after key milestones for overall team effectiveness. Moreover, it was explained how giving and receiving actionable and valuable feedback helps individuals and the team grow for project success. You concluded your reflection journal by designing an initial development goal you intend to address with your team and how you plan to implement feedback.

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Watch: Going Forward: Team Dynamics

An effective team takes time to build from the ground up. Ms. Georgiana offers some words of advice to ensure you are growing as an individual and as a team.

Video Transcript

We've covered a wide variety of content that can really help your team to be more effective and more efficient as you move forward. My hope is that you're able to really proactively apply some of the things that we've spoken about here with your teams, using your reflections from this course as a guide for these conversations. I hope that you take some time upfront in your teams to start the process of really building trust and gaining alignment and being open to each other to enable greater collaborative results out of your work together. I want you to push yourselves towards action and really good decision making and getting that forward momentum that will help you to achieve your goals. But lastly, and definitely not least, I want you to make sure that, as individuals and as a team you are growing, that you are using this experience to really inform how you work together as a team today. But also learnings from your team today about how you want to work together in future teams, ensuring that you can deliver outstanding results. Your overall team dynamic is going to make or break your team's success, so really make sure you're giving it the attention that it deserves. If you do, I'm confident that you will be on a great path to project success and overall goal achievement as a team. Good luck.